



Meetings 5–8: Clarifying Essential Learning

PLC Question 1 — What do we want students to learn? One journey in four steps.

The big picture

These four meetings are one journey, not four separate tasks. You start from your course's standards and narrow to a shared, concrete picture of what students must learn and what proficiency looks like — so the common assessment you design next is built on one definition, not five.

Meeting	What your team does	What you leave with
Meeting 5 Identify	Use the REAL filters — Readiness, Endurance, Assessed, Leverage — to choose the one essential standard to guarantee this cycle.	One selected essential standard.
Meeting 6 Deconstruct	Break that standard into learning targets — the knowledge and skills behind it — in student-friendly “I can...” language.	Draft learning targets.
Meeting 7 Define proficiency	Agree on what “they've learned it” looks like, and build success criteria for the targets.	Success criteria for each target.
Meeting 8 Calibrate	Write proficiency anchors, compare them, and refine your success criteria into one shared picture.	An agreed picture of proficiency.

How the pieces stack: the standard is the promise → the learning targets are the steps → the success criteria are how you'll know a student arrived. Meeting 8 locks in that shared picture before any assessment is written.

One tool to think with, one sheet to capture

Each meeting pairs a method tool (how to think) with a capture sheet (where you write it down). You don't need more than that.

Meeting	Think with	Capture on
5	Using REAL to Identify Essential Standards (Solution Tree)	EMS Essential Standards Organizer
6	EMS Learning Target Breakdown — Deconstructing an Essential Standard (Solution Tree) is optional	EMS Learning Target Breakdown
7	Gaining Shared Clarity (Solution Tree)	Developing a Success Checklist (Solution Tree)
8	Proficiency Anchors protocol (write, compare, refine)	EMS Proficiency Anchors

Meeting 8 builds a shared definition of proficiency — but it is not scoring calibration. You can't truly calibrate scores until students have taken the common assessment, so that real calibration comes later, after the first CFA. For now, the team agrees on what proficient looks like.